



ONE-STAR CAST: (From left) Goa Chief Minister Digambar Kamat, actors Priyamani and Khan, I&B Minister P.R. Dasmunshi

Finally, Just Films

No celebrity sightings, no stage shows, not even any slips. Cinema took centrestage this year despite the International Film Festival of India coming at the tail-end of the global movie season.

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

There was no Bipasha Basu with her *beedi* this year. Neither was Salman Khan trying to dance with Priyanka Chopra. The lack of international names didn't help either. But if there was one thing that was conspicuous by its absence at the 38th International Film Festival of India (IFFI) in Goa last week, it was Bollywood, its stars, stage shows and soirees. Shah Rukh Khan, who inaugurated the festival—a sombre ceremony compared to last year—carried the glamour quotient solely on his new six-pack. Considering the star's closeness to the Gandhi family, it might just have been the Congress's way of making a point. In 2005, an invitation was extended to Amitabh Bachchan to inaugurate the festival, but was withdrawn at the last moment, presumably owing

to his proximity to the Samajwadi Party. Though Khan and Bachchan have been proclaiming their love for each other despite speculation of a rift, this cat and mouse game at IFFI has opened a new can of worms.

The films, however, made up for the politics and the no-star show. Starting with Christian Mingiu's inaugural Romanian film *Four Months, Three Weeks, Two Days*, to Aki Kaurismaki's

Lights in the Dusk and the South African *Tsotsi*, the Cinemas of the World selection was a film aficionado's 35-mm dream. "The focus this time is on films rather than glamour," said filmmaker Sudhir Mishra. The Indian Panorama section, too, represented the best of regional cinema, from Marathi films like Bipin Nadkarni's *Aevdhe Se Aabhal* (A Home in the Sky) to the Manipuri musical *Yenning Amadi Likla*

ON THE SIDELINES...

Having received flak from BCCI for promoting his film *Om Shanti Om* at cricket matches, Shah Rukh Khan addressed cricket lovers at the inauguration of IFFI, saying, "Now I'm promoting sports at a film event." He may have lost BCCI's favour, but he's clearly not lost his cheekiness.

Making the most of the festival, Ketan Mehta and actor-wife Deepa launched the Indian Independent Filmmakers Worldwide website to give filmmakers of Indian origin a platform. "It won't start out as a funding organisation. It will be the first step in organising this creative chaos," said Mehta.